classified as natural sources and man-made sources. Some of the sources of water pollution are explained below.

a. Household detergents

Household and cleaning detergents are a major cause of water pollution. Synthetic (non-biodegradable) detergents have chemicals that do not break down and can end up polluting both surface and groundwater. Excessive use of detergents adversely affects fish and other organisms. Some shampoo, face wash, shower gel and toothpaste have small round pieces of plastic added to them. These are called microbeads. They are added for different reasons like scrubing and cleaning your skin, polishing your teeth etc. When we use products with microbeads, they go down our drain and pollute water bodies. Fish and other animals feed them by accident and get sick.

Activity 7

Take a shampoo, shower gel or other product you think might have micro-beads in it. Mix two tablespoons of this in a glass of water and stir it well. Pour the water in a black t-shirt filtering the micro-beads out.



b. Domestic Sewage

Wastewater that is disposed of from households is known as domestic sewage. Domestic sewage should be treated before being disposed of into water bodies like river, lake, etc. Untreated sewage contains impurities such as organic matter from food waste, toxic chemicals from household products and it may also contain disease-causing microbes.

DO YOU KNOW?

The largest source of water pollution in India is untreated sewage. On an average, a person uses 135 litres of water per day for washing clothes, cooking, bathing, etc.

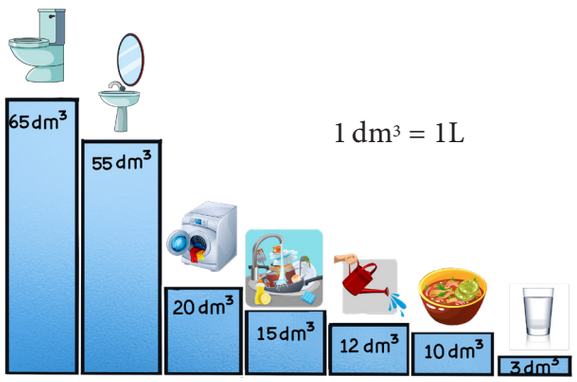


Figure 13.10 Domestic water consumption

c. Domestic waste and plastics

Solid waste including plastics are disposed of or end up in water bodies such as lakes, rivers and the ocean. Plastics block drains spreading vector borne diseases such as malaria and dengue. Waste in water bodies, negatively impact aquatic life.



Figure 13.11 Plastics in domestic wastes

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